Rabea Hinsching

PhD Candidate in Economics | E-Mail | Website | LinkedIn | GitHub

Research Interests: Development Economics, Natural Resources, Political Economy, Corporate Social Responsibility

Education

10/2022 – present **PhD in Economics**
University of East Anglia
• Thesis: "Three Essays on Mining, Corporate Social Investment, and Local Development in South Africa"
• Supervisors: Oana Borcan (UEA, UK), Christa Brunnschweiler (NTNU, Norway) & Ben D'Exelle (UEA, UK)
• Examiners: Jens Prüfer (internal; Tilburg University, NL, and UEA, UK) & Juan Pablo Rud (external; Royal Holloway, University of London, UK)

07/2025 – 08/2025 **Visiting PhD Researcher**
Gauteng City-Region Observatory

10/2019 – 04/2022 **MSc Economics / Development Economics**
University of Leipzig and Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne

09/2016 – 07/2019 **BSc Politics, Psychology, Law and Economics (PPLE)**
University of Amsterdam

Current Papers

- The Limits of Firm-Led Development: Evidence from South African Mining Communities
  Job Market Paper / Chapter 1 of PhD Thesis
- Corporate Social Investment, Political Participation, and Trust in Local Government
  Chapter 2 of PhD Thesis
- Can Large-Scale Mining Promote Public Good Provision? Evidence from South Africa's Mining Reform
  Chapter 3 of PhD Thesis

Work in Progress

- Assessing the Impact of the Broad-Based Livelihood Programme in Gauteng's East Rand Mining Communities
  In collaboration with Umsizi Sustainable Solutions; Work-in-Progress
- Increasing Legitimacy of Mining Companies' CSR Investments
  With Christa Brunnschweiler, Sonwabile Mnwana and Mare Sarr; Project proposal, seeking funding

- Corporate Social Investment Tracker
  Dataset of corporate social investment projects | Beta Version

Teaching Experience

03/2024 – 05/2026	**Teaching Assistant** University of East Anglia • Undergraduate: Environmental Economics, Statistics for Economists, Behavioural Finance • Postgraduate: Applied Methods for Impact Evaluation
09/2023 – 05/2026	**Tutor** The Brilliant Club • Teaching placements of own and pre-designed courses at local secondary schools.

Conferences

09/2026	16th ifo Dresden Workshop on Regional Economics, ifo Dresden (Germany)
12/2025	Conference on the Future of Development Economics, University of Manchester (UK)

Summer Schools

09/2025	Twenty-Fourth Summer School in International and Development Economics: Geo-economics, Natural Resources, and Development, Gargonza (Italy)
07/2024	Applied Econometrics for Spatial Economics – 22nd LSEG Summer School, Lisbon (Portugal)

Additional Experience

04/2026 – present	**Data Research Assistant** *Economic Inquiry*
2025/26	**Postgraduate Research Committee Member** University of East Anglia
2025/26	**Co-Reviewer** Nature Communications – Early Career Researcher Co-Review Initiative
2022	**Volunteer (Weltwärts)** Madikwe Rural Development Programme, South Africa
2020 – 2022	**Student Research Assistant** Fraunhofer IMW and IWH (Financial Markets Department)

Skills

Methods	Causal Inference, Event Studies, Spatial Analysis, LLM-based Data Extraction
Software	Stata, R, Python, QGIS, LaTeX, SPSS
Languages	German (native), English (proficient)

Abstracts of Current Papers

The Limits of Firm-Led Development: Evidence from South African Mining Communities

Job Market Paper / Chapter 1 of PhD Thesis

This paper evaluates the impact of mining companies' Local Economic Development programmes (LEDs), which aim to increase incomes and reduce poverty in host communities by promoting alternative livelihood strategies and entrepreneurship. I compile a novel LED project database and combine it with seven waves of geo-coded household data from South Africa's Gauteng Province. Using an event-study framework, I compare outcomes in LED-receiving areas before and after project implementation. The results show persistent improvements in food security and an increased likelihood of receiving an income. However, effects on business ownership are short-lived, while employment and average income levels remain largely unchanged. The results are driven by Alternative Livelihoods Programmes (ALPs), which promote income diversification. The results suggest that LEDs can reduce markers of absolute deprivation, yet fall short of delivering fundamental change.

Corporate Social Investment, Political Participation, and Trust in Local Government

Chapter 2 of PhD Thesis

Through Corporate Social Investment (CSI), companies seek to contribute to the development of their operating areas, taking over responsibilities usually held by local governments. This paper investigates whether CSI affects citizens' government perception and political participation at the local level. I focus on mining-related CSI in South Africa's Gauteng Province and combine information on CSI projects with household survey and electoral data. Using an event-study design, I estimate the effects of CSI on political participation, as well as trust in and satisfaction with local government. The results suggest that CSI projects increase community-level political participation, measured by attendance at community meetings, but have no meaningful impact on government trust or satisfaction. CSI-receiving areas show higher participation in subsequent municipal and ward elections, suggesting spillovers to electoral participation. Together, these findings suggest that CSI can mobilise citizens to participate more actively in local politics without weakening trust in government institutions.

Can Large-Scale Mining Promote Public Good Provision? Evidence from South Africa's Mining Reform

Chapter 3 of PhD Thesis

This paper examines whether mining can strengthen local service delivery when companies are required to invest in local public goods. I use South Africa as a case study, where post-apartheid reforms introduced such requirements alongside a fundamental overhaul of local governance and service delivery, providing a useful starting point for examining this question. Using census data from 2001 to 2022, I compare access to basic services across mining and non-mining municipalities, focusing on gold and Platinum-Group Metals (PGM) mining and four services: electricity, water, sanitation, and refuse removal. I instrument mining presence with municipalities' overlap with exogenously determined mineral deposits and control for baseline levels of service provision. I find that PGM mining post-apartheid is associated with significantly

higher access to basic services, while the evidence is weaker for gold mining. These effects are not explained by increases in municipal revenues or improvements in institutional quality. Instead, the findings are consistent with a combination of additional mining-related investment and a broader crowding-in effect, whereby mining activity stimulates public investment in service infrastructure in mining areas.

References

Christa Brunnschweiler
Professor in Economics, Department of Economics, Norwegian University of Science and Technology, Norway

Oana Borcan
Associate Professor, School of Economics, University of East Anglia, UK

Ben D'Exelle
Professor in Economics, School of Global Development, University of East Anglia, UK